

Estranged

ESTRANGED

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E hele me ka Pu'olo

Dedicated to everyone who has left me better than I was before

Chapters

1

BARN SWALLOW

2

SLEEPING UDUMBARA

3

BASK IN MY SHADOW AS I FLY

4

PICKING THROUGH DEVoured PETALS

1

BARN SWALLOW

With Petty Hands
You've learned to harness

You've sewn the seeds,
Now reap the harvest.

The Loss

Your fingers hung limp,
Wilted in the beating sun,
Curled like a singeing paper held above a flame

Your breath was caught behind your still lips,
Locked away and caged, but
Sifting through the hollows of your ribs in every moment

Your heart was a tired bird, asleep on her perch in broad daylight.
With the wild desperation of a predator, clenching and pushing,
I tried to make her fly away

Your lips were cold and insipid
With every effort I exhaled my spirit into you

Against my chest, yours felt empty.

I held my breath hoping to feel yours.

Inadequate

Some things are better left untouched
But incessantly, I choose curiosity
Driving us deeper underground
So the clarity of daylight comes and goes without us noticing

How can I know which sunsets are worth watching?

If I never come up
Then I never have to choose
If I never hope
Then I never have to lose

Digging in
It's
A meticulous process of excavation
Brushing off bones with soft-bristles
Heavy bones that she couldn't go on with
And so, collapsing in this tundra
She turned her
Megafauna eyes to glimpse
The last green flash on the horizon
And miles of glorious fur that once shimmered in the copper sun
Eroded with no encore

Even with the sky before me
I will always wonder
What she held onto

Inadequate (Continued)

So maybe I am bad at grieving
If I'd rather sort pieces of the full picture
And arrange everything I've learned so far into a skeleton
Instead of setting off across the plains, blindly guessing where her feet fell
& Calling that "good enough"

But truly, for someone whose so against the past
You hold more weight in bones than me
A cranium, a frontal bone, a maxilla
Placed next to each other
But no mandible (so good luck saving face)
It's not a bad collection
They just have no connection
Yet, you carry them with you
Without keeping a map
Without ever going back to investigate further
It seems obvious—
There are better ways to use your strength
Than lugging around fragmented memories
Without an explicit intent

Still, I question all the time
With all this time spent underground
Am I missing the point?
Will I ever experience the simple things that brought her joy?
Was there truly more to offer on the surface?
Or did I already overcomplicate it
By ceaselessly searching in the first place?

Enough?

Haven't I done enough?

Made enough issues already?

I keep seeing problems
But were there even any?

Am I defending my honor?
Waging a noble war against injustice?

Or am I shadowboxing in a room with just me?

Why do I always get the urge, how do I always work up the nerve
To keep resisting?

One More Night

Just

One more sunset, gone unseen

Just

One night, then another, then another

On top of these untucked sheets

Hesitant to stir this

Settled air

Summer heat

Continuing to ask myself, half-heartedly,

What am I allowed to keep?

I find you in the marrow of ordinary things

Wishful Thinking

Clasped as twins in the damp womb of night
Sifting on, you kept your eyes open
I believe they were
Cold as hazel mud

For a glimpse, the white birch spoke
Like rain-soft songs of famished past
I thought I heard the wild rush of your breath once more
But I was mistaken

The Cage

Behind closed doors
Phantom hands crawl to inundate
Blinded by need
Tracing over veiled pallor

In darkness
Hope pools at the threshold
Reaching nothing

Fluttering lungs sucked dry
Wasted and waning
As brittle limbs fold
Lamb to the slaughter

Nails open skin
Peeling from trembling bones
When flesh is too fragile to hold you together

Nails open skin
With sick and pulsing lacerations
Piercing presence
Aching body
Subdued

Return

The purple flowers along the stream

Shrivel under your step

The wind tearing at my hair makes it impossible to see the hillside path ahead. Soon enough the rain washes away the horizon. I am as water, rushed into the ocean with the stream.

Steadfast.

Our Ocean keeps breath in your lungs

Against all odds, you survive.

It's a fantastic world; alien and beautiful. Time is not measured here, and everything seems to be a work of art; thoughtfully assembled, priceless and unique. It's an impossible realm, yet so close to home for those who seek it . . .

Displaced,

You are carried back to shore. You wake up to the warmth of sun-dried rocks against your skin.

You step onto the unfamiliar land.

Everything you know, washed away . . .

Return.

Run back to the ocean, with your heart overflowing

Into a River of Joy, which you can follow to your destiny.

Its Getting Dark

It's getting dark.

You're shouting.
Beating, denting hull

I'm vacant.
Bleeding, sinking vessel

It's getting dark but I won't pull my anchor

Instead, let's just drift here

Let the water move our bodies

Just let the night wash me out

Soon, everything will be okay.

Smother & Forget

Claws that pry at the lockbox
Subconscious fighting to push out the crumbs curdling inside
Stitched and sealed into the pillow
Bread mold on soft cotton; Oxidized.

Close the lid of the cradle
She finds the noise unbearable
She keeps it shut and writes her letters
Lets the room blur out of focus, sights so forgettable
Breathe into nostalgia

Unbearable recollections bloating and floating to resurface
So she holds them under
She watches them stilled and smothered
While she breathes

& Raggedly utters

“Heal”

A Refuge Is A System

She said she knew you once before

Slighted gaze
Sweetened wine

Watercolor blossoms
Wrapping each other like dragons
As our
Fifth elements
Unwind

Teardrop as opposed to the whole expression
Me as a person being trapped in the forest vs. the force of the full forest
Symbiotic in a cruel way

A beautiful expression despite the dangers to me

I was a baby squirrel
Desperately running to a human when I found my mother dead

You see?
That's how the forest claims its senses
There are those who fall in rhythm with the refuge
Then there are those who rest on top
If you stay still for long enough,
The forest climbs around you
Twisting the line between

A refuge is a system

All creatures

Wrapped in roots

Hide Behind

You hide behind
A stray sunray
Colored by rainbow lenses
Illusory is all there is
Unanswered; kept inside

You hide behind
A pain of glass
Stained by interpretations
Soon to have it dawn on you
There's nowhere you can hide

You hide behind
A veil of truth
That no one else can question
Lest they crash against the headlands
Jutting from your mind

You hide behind
A puncture wound
Scarred over as aggression
I'm looking for a glimpse of
Recognition in your eyes

Like A Carcass

Like a

Carcass

My

Calculations

Are only as good

As my body lasts

When I

Give in

To tiredness

I am betraying myself

By wiping clean

The thoughts I'd given such importance...

Why did the rat's mind evolve, but not the body?

So they could long for their puphood

In the jaws of the snake?

Why do whales sing

Not knowing if they'll get an answer?

Leave

More often I used to get struck with the need
To forget everything that I know and just leave

Suddenly now it has come back again
Seemingly there at the fault of my friends

But are they to blame? Or are they just people
Living their lives unashamed and as equals

Each person doing their best to get by
Each looking out for their future, but I

Can't see a life that I want to pursue
Without taking notes and comparing with you

I don't see a point to staying above water
When I thought the plan was to float with each other

If there's a purpose that's worthy of mention
Show me right now, while I'm paying attention

Trying to hold on to keep my friends safe
Was somewhat effective for keeping me sane

Knowing instead they perceive it as danger
Means I need to understand that they're strangers

I'm not gonna tell myself "I should have known"
Because there was no harm in trying to hold hope

Leave (Continued)

Now I just have to create a new life
Without empathy for my friend's pain and strife

If you live for them, they'll only resent you
They'll say you should do whatever you want to

But what if I just want to feel loved and rooted?
I didn't realize that means I am wounded

I will not beg you to tend to my wounds
When things get tough, I'll step out of the room

When things get tougher, I'll forget what I know
Sadly, this place is no longer a home

2

SLEEPING UDUMBARA

“If one does not grasp the essence of existence,
Like the udumbara flower on a fig-tree;
That bhikkhu abandons the here and the beyond,
As a snake abandons its old slough.”

Sutta Nipāta 5.14

Hyacinth

Find

A bolder love than mine

Focus your vision

Through torrential downpours

& Find

Another silhouette

Peering back at you

Waiting

With drenched clothes clinging to her frigid body

As she fights the tremors

Honing in on the distance

Siphoning focus into each moment

To stretch them into tactile milliseconds

Anticipating, with every bit of herself

When it might be safe

To sprint to your embrace

Find

Another semblance of legacy

Stay quiet

Amidst the soft call of the winds

To hear what the Eternal Observer

Might tell you

In reflection

Find

A way to lie to yourself

To persuade your conscience

That you did right by me

Find

Another daughter

Because I've wasted the biggest fraction of my fragmented life

In a state of thankless hope

You were gifted

The purity of a child's unconditional love

And I've spent too long wondering

Why

You couldn't hold that

Reaper

Clenched in the gnarled fingers of the trees
Bound upon a bed of thistled vines
Looking up to watch the sunblaze stifle
Looking up to watch the night leak from black branches
The leafless lifeless reapers, desperate to absorb life
I am a sacrifice to these hallows
I am the compost they will drink
Here, where nature's heart dried out
I am the atrium to their droughted ventricles

Night brings heavy mist
As sclera seeping over the pupil
Obstructing senses, but bearing perfect foresight
Clarity to the mind's eye
Awaiting the descent

Listening for aberrations in the nocturnal drone
Quiet; then
The hunting bird's shriek pierces the muffled darkness
The shrill undertone shivers through the woods
Sunken to the earth
Waiting for my scent to catch in the wind and carry to predators
So they can eat off my stinging mangled limbs
And pick their teeth with my broken bones

The Last Day

That first night
Spilling blood dispersed the sky
Emulsified in rabid eyes
And purple fog poisoned the ones who were left alive

I blinked and realized I couldn't see
I listened for clearings in droning soliloquies
Startled by sudden noise, chasing the silence to safety
I felt my feet bounding behind and before me
In skipping strides, I'm meant to flee

As I ran, my senses shifted
I saw the forest tinted like parchment
And the scents were ink strokes on a map
Each snapping twig rang like a chorus
I followed the sound with bared teeth,
Euphoria possessing me as I closed in
In breathless exhilaration, I'm meant to feed

Out of darkness, color found me
Lungs of dust resounded
I felt my body uncrumple, pressed to a thudding chest
I was fed and held as I rested
In nurturing love, I am meant to be

This last day,
Roaring winds move the sky like living water
The air is filled with boundless love in my presence
And I can see it all

Dawning

You truly are a selfish asshole

At a level I've never seen before

I'm mad at myself for defending you

I'm mad at myself for every reason I used to convince myself of your goodness

I saw God's hand in your design

I saw Elysium in your eyes

I saw you as a bodhisattva

I envisioned helping the world with you by my side

But then

Like the

Popping eyes of a brocket deer

Who lost a long fight against

The pressure of constriction,

I'm left staring at empty sockets

You're wretched to me now

I finally realize why you can't believe you are beautiful.

Because you've lied to yourself for so many years.

In My Absence

So if you ask a question
And I take a ragged breath to answer
But before I speak, you ask another
Do I defy you, love?

If we spend a day apart
And you choose to hide your pain
By convincing yourself life is better in my absence
What intentions do you keep when we're together?

If I'm such a cost to you
Tell me how you're keeping score
Because all that I set out to do
Was offer you an equal

If your love's been lost and found
Tell me why it's missing now
And why you tried to offer something
You didn't have to give

Late To Forever

I don't even want forever
If I could just keep hope alive
Instead of choking the possibility at the roots
That would be enough

I don't know if I'd rather have
The letters of a child's name
Sing a song of love and rage
Falling short every day
Shoes filled with sands of time
Heavy with self-disdain

Or a garden to walk through
Each summer I could show someone else
The plants I've worked diligently to restore each year

Or a coffin for my grandmother's dress
Draped over my useless bones
An expensive monument to life
A flower arrangement
Thrown out after the funeral

Or a museum with my name on it
With an exhibit for the rocks from your travels
And a picture of me hung up on each wall

I don't know if I'd rather
Come home and see you smile
Or stay gone, asleep in a guest bed
Twirling a ring on the hand of a thief

I don't know if I'd rather
Keep my eyes open or closed
I don't know if there's a point to remembering this

Or Don't

Help me or don't
Love me or don't
But don't lead me on
Into having false hope

Relentless

Suspended in the moment between dusk and morning light,

The relentless sun lies peacefully asleep under the sky.

The breaking dawn leaves shadows and takes silhouettes,

So that the faceless forms you painted will wake up and forget,
Daylit expressions sullen with regret.

The space between the striking match and its box finds the spark

The flame compels a memory of flickering meadowlarks

How innocent the fingertips of kids who play with fire;

How swiftly the flame will burn their funeral pyre

Glorified

When the golden lion lays out in the sun
She does it for the glory
Her heart is hard-won

I want to be your majesty, your muse, your inspiration
When I don't at first have words to speak, I want you to be patient

I don't need a second person to call out my limitations
I want you to drink up all my thoughts
And bask in the libation

I'm not looking to fight
I'm just looking for an equal
And since the first try was in vain, I don't care to see the sequel

Unneeded

I know you didn't think of it that way
But when you said, "I know how to take care of myself,"
I was left to contend with the fear that I might never be needed.

Your boundaries are within reason
But for some reason, when you told me you needed space
I thought, "It's not my fault you're drained,
So why would you take yourself out of my life?"

That's why you can't be too kind to a girl who hasn't had anyone else to rely on; she'll start to treat you
like a lifeline. Then she'll expect you to need her as much as she needs you.

As we drift, the line gets pulled taut
Eventually, the microfibers fray
Leaving all the pressure on overstretched threads —
— So I can see why that would make you snap

But I don't know what you want me to do
When I'm in desperate need of rescue
Just holding on trying to survive

Love From Beyond

A sense of dissociation & separation from myself
I used to shrink and grimace at the thought
Of intimate companionship
And avoid myself in the same conversation

A sense of desperation
I remember falling down the spiral
With no one there to hold me
I close my eyes & look to the sky
Holding my chest in silent prayer for my younger self
As the spring of heartbreak swells up
Until it rushes from Anāhata like a geyser

Knowing it is the source of life,
I meld it to create
A steady channel
Of abundance
Sending
Love from beyond

The Fields

I wonder if you knew this place.

I like to think of you living in the rolling winds,
Which still seem to bend around your shape next to mine;
The memory I invent when I close my eyes.

The fullness of your presence hummed in my quiet mind
So long ago that I forgot the feeling

But each day I step out of a reticent layer of myself that keeps me separate from you,
And every time, I lose a part of myself to the clarity of spirit that comes from time alone

So of course I'd find you here,

With everything you love

A Place To Lay Your Head

She watched the blue lace trace the water like a kite string
In a faraway life, there was someone floating dead
Someone whose moss-bedded fingernails once threaded through a child's thin hair
Weaving pink ribbons together with dark braids

A woman who held close warmth within hugging arms
Now only a half-asleep smile

Someday, somewhere, a mother lies sodden like a pillow in a puddle
A girl curls to sleep on a sopping mattress
That heavy, ugly comfort
Barely wrung beneath her small body

The skirt was unbearably cold
And the blue lace was shredded when you tried to pull it
So the pretty things died with the woman in the mud
And that was that. There was no farewell song.

It seems like forever ago.

She Is Celestial

She isn't the shape they know.

They saw a still form against a flat night
One white stroke on a canvas
Poised for their pleasure
They praised her beauty, sang of her seductive nature, lamented her as elusive,
Embedding implications, too distant for her to hear.
For a while she was safe; untouched by lust
But their hands worked against her towards alluring luminescence
Prospective profit or power or prowess sought in forbidden frontiers
Regardless of her, they breached depths they shouldn't reach
And left footprints that won't blow away

That was in the light
The tantalizing light she wished she could shed
She wished she could curl into unlit craters and never be seen
But she stayed standing, not for dignity, but for necessity
Dutifully passing by, she has no choice but to move forward
Stripped even of her permission to grieve, because who could be lonely in a sky full of stars?
They don't know how empty it is when you are inside it
They don't know what they don't see

Her tears fell as stars, and he followed them to find her
He was drawn into her darkness, knew it was a part of her
Sought to truly know her
He is pulled to her, so close in the cosmos that they feel each other's gravity
He encompasses life; deep within his craters there are glowing creatures
And each day she curls into him, only seen by him
She can finally rest in his embrace.
She sees her light in a broken reflection on his surface, and she smiles at the illumination that once
betrayed her
Because here together in incandescence, they worship the shadow that defines them
His lips lap upon her scars, his sleeping breaths blow away the footprints
Every aspect of each other is visible, and they are complete

In him, she is not a shape
A brush stroke
A resource
A nightlight

In him, she is celestial.

3

BASK IN MY SHADOW AS I FLY

In my life
I've learned how
To return to my body

To love every part of myself
Even my fringed tailfeathers
& Catch wind
Undaunted by the wrath of the Sun

I am almost entirely
Self-taught

Night Nymph

Immerse me in perfect isolation
Inner light
Cast away from false creation
Delicate white
Daylily resigned to
Decay and blight

Somehow both
Empty yet opulent
Godless & divine

Cocooned in my mausoleum
Elusively defined by
A Flickering flame for life
A Faltering faith in a perfect design
Diminished
Atomized

Sheltered in a house that isn't mine
Illusory prison of a
Labyrinthian mind
Unspoken fate
Substrate leeches and lysed
Seeds in the wind floating through
Untethered time
Carried underwing of
The Nymph of the night

The Sky

In all the places I find myself

The only thing that's always been there is the sky

That's why I excitedly point out clouds to friends

And silently gaze up in reverence

When I'm alone

Fodder

Lay your beliefs about me like eggs in open wounds

Breeding through my flesh and burrowing holes to bones

Bleeding me out until I shrivel

like

the creatures

in my windowsill

bodies long expired, curled into postures of decomposure,

but without soil,

they are worthless.

Lizards with eye sockets pecked clean

Bodies erect and poised to flee

Frozen in their cowardice,

Displayed.

The shock of paralysis and the finality of rigor mortis sink me like a stone.

My lungs fill with water as the ocean helps itself to what's left of me.

It trickles through my festering veins,

The salt drawing out my infection.

It's enough to contaminate

an infinitesimal corner

of the boundless sea.

Tundra

Elemental changes are
Embedded in the nature of it
Her eyes, softened with love
Forever set on the west sky of Dryas
Never saw the tundra melt

Instead, she asked the Sun a question

As the only Ward and Warden of her Holocene dreamscape,
She follows the ebb and flow of dwindling, sparkling hope
Wayfinding through starless skies
With razor-sharp resolve, she wears
The acquiescent beauty of surrender
Alongside her bandaged pride

“If I speak, would you care to know?”

Loyalty is a wordless language
Patiently, she wonders
If the sun rises to shine upon her
Or if the moonlit mysteries
Are all she has to keep

Resilience grows inside her
Her lungs are full of ivy
She feels it undeniably with every breath —
The only recognizable thing that’s left of her
Is
Non-indigenous

“Does it count?” she asks herself
(Whoever that may be)

Tundra (Continued)

Time and time again and again, she deliberately gets lost in lingering memories
Searching for more lessons in them
Finding only phantom pains

It's the closest guaranteed glimpse of simplicity and familiarity
Like returning to the arms of an old friend

The flinching stopped so long ago now

Respect is the fruitless seed of blind faith.

It serves

Only as a trellis for the vines to claim

The skeleton goes on renewing itself
Even when she tells every cell in her body
That she wishes time would freeze

Maybe she could close the chapter
If this Earth for once admitted,

“You were brave,
I was cold.”

Recognition & Reverence

I am here;
Face to face with you, but
Glycerin coats my pores

& I am just a witness.

"Gift from heaven" was the invocation spoken at my birth

but *"Eternal blossom"* was the first

~ So meet me in this moment

For exactly what it is

Because I need space to grow as much as you do

Sonderly,
We find water
When it's needed

Golden Fleece

Indecision

I saw you through the eyes of a mother

What was so heavy

Now enlightened

Heedless freedom in the form of

The murder of a child

Stained golden fleece

Fallen to the floor

Hands on a spinning wheel

You had two unbroken strings

Mine were frayed

Either way, you were always

Taking years you never had to give

Thanklessly

A quiet syphon

You spoke like water

Digging up glass vials

After years of evaporation

I spoke the pain of a clairvoyant

Fleets of chariots & fire

Poured from my mouth

An equal reaction

The voice of reality saying

“This isn’t over”

Pink

When I die I want to be a zombie worm

With my

Feathers blooming out gloriously

Brushing the sea floor like

A paint stroke of azalea pink

Standing like a well-fed flamingo

Growing out of the bones of giants

Pointlessly mesmerizing

For no one to see

Forgotten Toys

You wonder why I'm still here

Well, my dear

I'm not nearly as greedy with the word "love" as you are

You and I

Both see your worth

And I thought I could be the bigger person

And show you how trust works

But I'm surely not infallible

I arrived with threadbare fur & a plain felt heart, once filled with a child's dreams

If you want to pull me apart, so be it

You could do so easily

To forgotten toys like me

Better Than Human

To be better than human,
You have to stop thinking like a human
You have to stop acting like a human

To be better than human,
You have to convince yourself that somewhere along the straight line stretching ahead through the vast horizon there is a fork in the road, and you have to take that imaginary exit to God-knows-where.
You have to give fully into playing out what's least expected
Just to see where it ends

To be better than human, you have to fold when you should hold, lay when you're supposed to stand, run when you're supposed to stay, scream when the silence falls, panic when the lights go out, stay up all night feeling more alive than ever when there is no one around you who could bring you back to life. You have to relish in the fact that it might take weeks to find the body. You have to brood on your private life until privacy is all you have. You have to cut strong tendons & leave them hanging just to prove that you care more about proving a point than you care about living.

And if you complete these protocol,
If you focus on letting these habits evolve,
You will successfully be
Inhuman
In the eyes of the outside world

Indifference

You should be begging at my feet for forgiveness for what you said

Your indifference to me reared its ugly head

And now that I've seen it, I can't unsee it

So I'm revoking your privilege to witness my life

As I forge my way forward, resilient and remarkable

Something I've Stopped Believing In

In little creeks on wooded walks, I saw the sky's reflection
I've seen you seeing yourself, glinting in my eye's reflection.

Sprigs o' water hyacinths, outstretched to swaying canopies
Sunlight upon me, Epidermal flinch; A flight reflection.

Dissipated out of sight, a fleeting commemorative blaze...
Clouds will only show themselves while holding the Light's reflection.

Of heaven, of the Earth, is there any other origin?
Is it true, the space between, grows thin in divine reflection?

My palms will match the lamina, my Goldenessent presence
Here I am, material, but preferring my reflection.

From this perspective, I'd have gambled I would float above it
Wisdom's weight grounds me down with logic, in untimed reflection.

Brown eyes fixed upon me like I was from a different planet
That's a good question; Do I have a "self" outside reflection?

Regardless, Snowdrops accommodate ice that grows within them
Inside Eternal blossom lies a crystallized reflection

Starlight

Into the night
Immersed in space & removed from time
Held breath
Tranquil sigh
Glimpse of obsidian & stars shimmering white
Held in place by the expansive divine
At peace within the
Embrace of the sky

Landscape

As snow absorbs the ashes, awakened conscience falters
Underneath, true nature waits
Exposed to air, ice melts away

Growing forest to reclaim,
Where you can live with your pain

Wholeness

The trees forget their individuality
And join with the horizon into a single organism,
Drawing millions of breaths as one
With the power to pull the wind out of the valley
And the air out of my sun-gold body
Until it is impossible to hold on to the Self
So I become a silhouette
And join the trees in the skyline

4

PICKING THROUGH DEVoured PETALS

“Do not forever with thy vailèd lids
Seek for thy noble father in the dust.
Thou know’st ’tis common. All that lives must die,
Passing through nature to eternity.”

Hamlet 1.2 72-75

Eternal

I truly believe this is heaven to another world
Each life is a process of molting
One day we will fill every place that's been touched by our love
And I'd like to span across the sky

Cypsela Lips

When we were weightless
Twirling like maple seeds
Windswept
Adrift, far away from our parent tree

I slept on your chest
& listened. Every
Steady inhale lifted me
On gentle moon tides
Into gentle sleep

Even when the cloudy daylight faded in,
I went on dreaming

I dreamt that
We could cherish this
Unchangingly
Yet
I understand, my Golden love
Your breath ~
Could not be mine to keep

When your lips
Depart from mine
It's like I've kissed
A dandelion

Softly as cypsela
Wherever the wind carries you;
That is where you'll be

Honeybee,
I seek for yellow efflorescent ground
Wherever you have walked, my darling
Wildflowers abound

Araphel

A tattered silhouette amid the dying light of day,
She sways.
Shaken by the winds which carry seeds to desolate lands
Who find solace in the silence
And bloom amidst the decay

She, The Christmas Rose,
Choked beneath the snow which once drifted delicately upon her petals
With the softest touch, and the coldest kiss,
So that she might glisten in the light

She stays
Because the snow shines like a sea of stars,
And she is warmed by the memory of the burning, living light.

Blame

Yes, I'm grieving
But it's not the grief you know
It's the kind that winds into your brain and binds at the edge of the skull
The kind that bats at the wind and hollows a space in your throat
Where a shout would have formed if it was relevant anymore

Thinking about all of the times I pushed forward
With my half-complete ideas, but what did I know?
Wondering why you believed in me so deeply
That you were willing to give your life to me

And with both of our life force within me, I'm still standing

But this wasn't at all how I planned it

You Said You Loved Me In A Dream

I want to be known & cherished

Like everybody does

I thought I saw a gleam of promise

A light so pure it'd never falter

From shining on me with love

But desire fades, my angel

That's why I always tried to ask you

If what I am

Is enough

I can keep my eyes ahead

But it's so hard to let go when

Last night you said you loved me in a dream

All I Have

All the tears I've cried for you
Have fallen in an ocean

Every careful word I speak
Is falling on deaf ears

If only I could reach you now
I'd soften you with closeness

Your heart's an empty bottlecast
Lost to the tides, my dear

August

Dahlia unfolds

Soul bleeds from her bodice

Cascading through limp fingers

Riveted glacier eyes, lighting-split
Dripping noir skies

Crystal-cold teardrops on her lip
Undulating dew, turgid scry

Her portrait cast in
Ivory oil and
Heavy charcoal
 smudged
 where
 opaline
 skin
 caves

... Dovewings graced with a small silver chain

Trace to her August locket,

Ember of

Kindled Esse

Within

Silence

Passing clouds, carry
me to ancient lands, where the
Earth is still and free

Where, in my silence,
I find purity and peace.
That is where I rest

Sunglow

She walks with sunglow in her wake.
I am the moon, falling forever into her reflection

She rushes into the Earth as lifeblood through healing wounds.
I am the canyon, filled as she floods the carapace of my consciousness

She is elusive, sensed but never held.
I reside in the winds which caress her immortal skin.

My musings drift as petals onto her surface

And ripple across the still waters of time

Viento

Like birdsong on a windy morning,
If she speaks, you should listen closely

A curve of full and gentle lips
Like sunlight on an autumn day
Drifting through the falling leaves
Gracing Earth soft-spokenly

As the forest resigns to be adorned in glimmering crystal frost
A chrysalis keeps safe inside the final drops of summer

So when it starts to open,
Listen to her heart
Or else you might miss
The most beautiful thing in the breeze...

Mending

No matter how cautiously the needle pulls
It still stabs when mending

In my box, I have
A spool wrapped with memories
(Following the coil into a spiral)
A pin cushion
(To impale guiltlessly without consequence)
A thimble
(Which I never use, because I'd risk bleeding before I inhibit myself from feeling)

The thread is what I am made of
Like it or not
Even if it is strong in some spots, weak in others
Who would think it is wise to throw out the whole spool
That many hands worked to create?

Tears can be mended
As long as there are memories
Stabbed into the fabric of my being

Almost Strangers

I didn't realize
How familiar you were
Until I didn't see you
On that cloudy morning
Lugging my bag of bones
Across the river to the old café
I stumbled on one August day
And habitually incorporated my
Daily vanilla oat milk latte
But more than that, there was you
Monday - Thursday
That same warm smile
On a freckled face
Chatting as you scribbled my name
A simple understanding exchanged
Since I always ordered the same thing
So deftly, your hands worked and made
This treat I once looked forward to
But now that you've moved on, I realized
Maybe what I looked forward to more than anything
Was seeing you

Unspoken

Origins of life dripping down stones of time
The soul force of this forest-
An elemental match to mine

Thousands of years worth of time spent alone
Sunsets went unwitnessed;
So many stories were left untold

Until we arrive like the Udumbara flower
Bringing gifts of love and light
Astonished by your power

We give thanks to Land, Water, and Sky
For holding us here
And providing our lives

Nothing Lasts Forever

It's true that nothing lasts forever
But some things are worth
Trying to hold onto